

Pursue Her After You Have Her

You can mean it when you say “love you” and still realize you haven’t paid much attention to her today. You know she’s there. You’d like a few minutes together, once everything else is done.

You ask how her day was. She says “fine.” You nod, finish something on your phone, and start talking about dinner. Nothing harsh passed between you. You might have that same exchange tomorrow.

Now think of a child bringing you a hand-drawn picture. You look up. You want to see it. You ask about the person beside the house, and you listen while the child explains. You’re glad they wanted to show you.

You already know how to give that kind of attention. With your wife, it can be as simple as setting the phone down when she starts talking. You know her well enough to recognize when something pleased her. Let yourself be pleased for her. Ask what happened next.

There’s pleasure in being the person she wants to tell.

When learning felt finished.

Imagine asking your wife out after twelve years of marriage. You’ve got some time free, and you want to spend it with her. You start thinking about what she’d enjoy.

The place you remember is somewhere she loved when you were dating. Would she still choose it? You think about the music she liked then, the way she used to spend a free Saturday. You can describe those things. What she’d choose now takes more thought.

You live with her. How can you be unsure?

She hasn't become a stranger. You still know how she takes her coffee and which jokes will make her laugh. But at some point, you stopped asking certain questions. You kept using the answers you already had.

That's the pre-commitment paradox: you can work hard to win a woman's affection, then ease off once you're sure of it. Before commitment, you wanted to hear what she thought. You remembered what excited her because you wanted another chance to enjoy it with her. Once you were married, learning about her could start to feel finished.

It makes sense that security changes things. You can relax together. You can be quiet without wondering whether she's lost interest. That's a good part of marriage. Taking her affection for granted is a costly mistake. You can lose the easy closeness of knowing what she's looking forward to, or being the person she wants to tell first.

Winning her affection was the beginning of a life together. The effort that follows deserves just as much of you. You keep making time, asking, listening, and following through, even in the years when being married feels easy.

She's still becoming.

In Letter 58 of his *Moral Letters to Lucilius*, the Stoic philosopher Seneca reflects on how people keep changing. He turns to an earlier philosopher, Heraclitus, and his image of the river: what looks familiar doesn't stay fixed. Its water keeps changing, and so do we.

Bring that thought home. Your wife has had twelve years of experiences since you married her. Some things matter more to her now. Others

matter less. She may have an interest you haven't asked about, or an old ambition she's begun to reconsider.

You've changed too. You have things you could tell her that wouldn't have occurred to you when you first met. Growing together takes some willingness to share those things, and some interest in hearing hers.

Pay attention to the people you're already becoming.

The date can begin with an honest question: "What sounds fun to you these days? I've been thinking about what we used to do." Suppose she says she'd rather spend the afternoon at a pottery class. She tried it with a friend last month and wants to go again. You knew she was out that afternoon. You hadn't asked what she'd enjoyed about it. Now you're hearing about the bowl she wants to make, and you want to see what she means. You can plan an afternoon around something she's enjoying now.

Be interested in her answer.

Maybe you've started watching different shows. You listen to one podcast, she listens to another. Separate tastes can give you something to talk about. You don't need to enjoy her show to enjoy hearing why she likes it.

Ask about the part that caught her attention. If she laughs while telling you, stay with the story long enough to understand what's funny. You may discover a side of her humor you haven't seen much lately. Tell her what's been making you laugh too. Let her hear more from you than a report of what got done.

You can also try something neither of you knows much about. Choose a walk through a part of town you rarely visit. Stop when something

interests her. Show her what catches your eye. Give yourselves a little time when neither person already knows what the other will say.

Curiosity becomes warmth in how you receive the answer. If she tells you something went well, pause what you're doing. Let her finish. Say what you're glad about. When you talk later, remember enough to return to it. You give her a reason to believe you enjoyed hearing from her.

The opposite can hurt without a single unkind word. You know where she'll be and what she'll handle, but little about what's been on her mind. She can feel unseen in a marriage where she's loved. If her stories keep meeting half your attention, she may tell you less. You can miss hearing from each other while sharing the same room.

You can begin with the next conversation. Then keep making room for what you learn. Ask how the bowl turned out. Find another afternoon to go with her. Remember what she enjoyed when you're making plans a month from now. That takes effort long after the first interested question.

Choose her today.

Some days "fine" means fine. Some days she's tired and wants to sit beside you without talking. An invitation leaves room for either. You can ask whether she feels like telling you more, then accept her answer without making her reassure you.

Your own tired days count too. You won't greet every story with excitement. A quiet, attentive husband can be good company. Keep saying "love you." Familiar words can carry years of meaning when your attention gives her reason to believe them.

After ten or twenty years, pursuit still asks for your time and energy. Keep learning what matters to her. Share what matters to you. You offer time together because you want her company, without requiring a particular response. Your choice to love her becomes visible again today.

The same desire to discover someone can draw your attention toward another woman, too. Pursuing your wife also calls for enjoying her without measuring her against someone else. The next chapter names how that comparison starts, and takes up the discipline of enough.

For now, put the phone down and turn toward her while she's still telling you about her day.

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when you were dating

now



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Chapter 13 Distillation — Pursue Her After You Have Her

Mechanism: Keep learning what matters to her

Conversation sentence: You can remember everything she loved when you were dating and still need to ask what she'd enjoy now.

She's still becoming. You've changed too. The answers you already had can't tell you everything about the woman beside you today. Ask what happened next. Be interested in her answer. Let yourself be pleased for her. Sustained effort means making time for those conversations and doing something with what you learn, year after year.

Lesson: Winning her affection begins a life of choosing her through sustained attention and effort.

Challenge: Familiarity makes it easy to rely on old answers; keep giving her time and attention without requiring a particular response.

PRACTICE

1. Once a week, make time together around something she enjoys now. Ask rather than relying only on what she liked when you were dating, and follow through on the plan.
2. When she tells you about something she's enjoying, set aside what you're doing and ask what caught her interest. Let yourself be pleased for her, and return to it another day.
3. When you're spending time together, tell her about something you've begun to enjoy or reconsider. Give her a chance to know who you're becoming too.